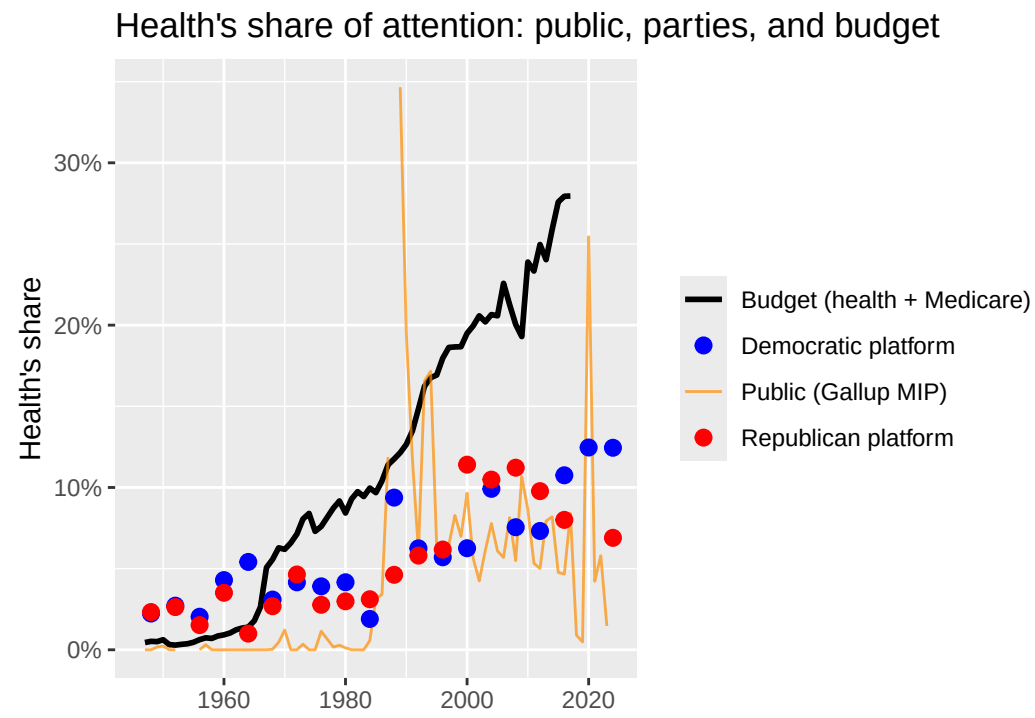
Attention vs. Money: Health in Public Opinion, Party Platforms, and the Federal Budget

Josh

Question

How much attention does health get in public opinion, in party platforms, and in the federal budget, and how do those compare over time? I use four U.S. Policy Agendas Project datasets: Democratic and Republican platforms, Gallup's Most Important Problem, and Budget Authority (Jones et al. 2025). Platforms and Gallup measure *attention*, not positions. The budget is a common baseline for what government is committed to.

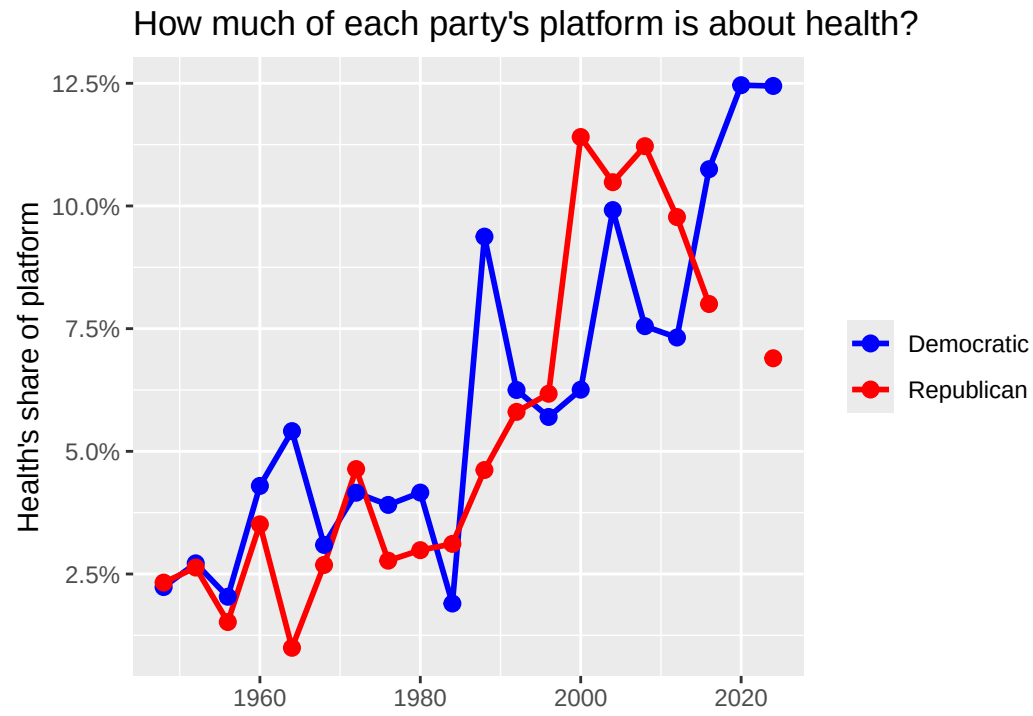
Figure 1: Four arenas



ferent denominators; compare timing and shape, not height.

Series use different denominators, so compare timing and shape, not height. Gallup 1988 is set to missing: only five topics were reported that year, so the zero for health is probably a thin-data artifact.

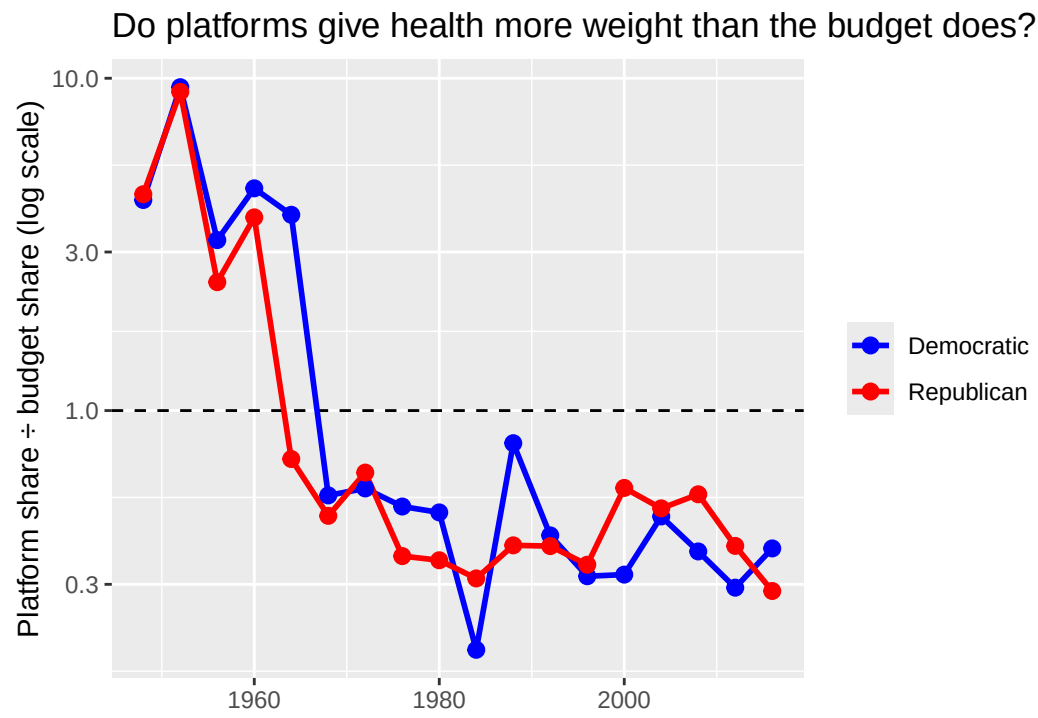
Figure 2: Democrats vs. Republicans



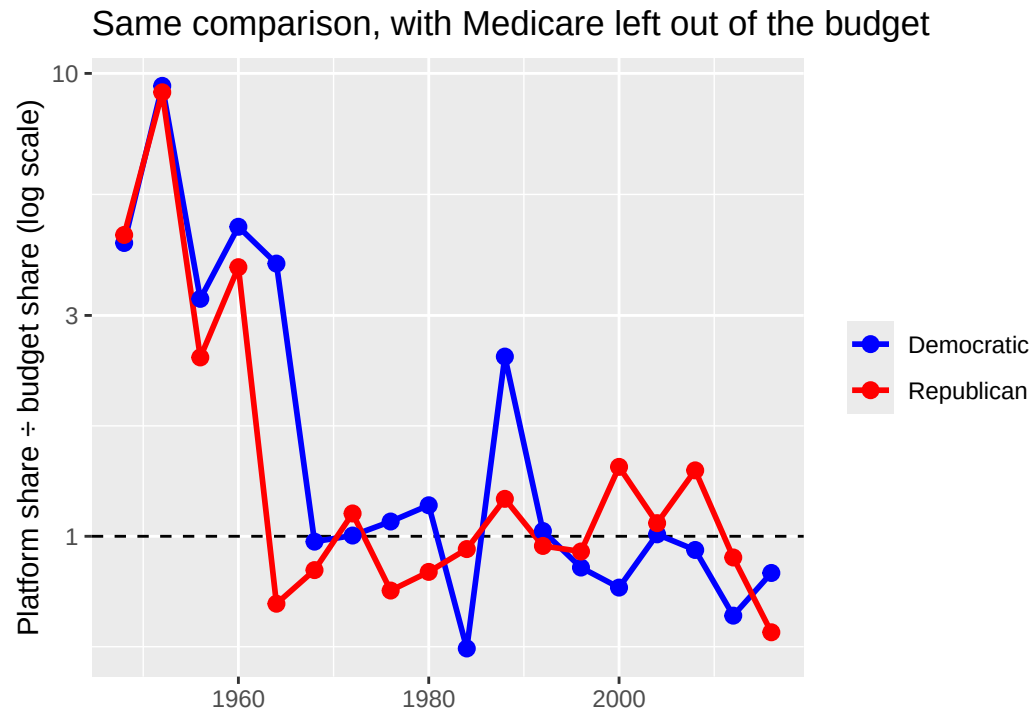
of policy sentences coded Health. Republicans adopted no platform in 2020.

Republicans adopted no new platform in 2020, so that line breaks.

Figure 3: Platforms vs. the budget



is a bigger slice of the platform than of the budget. Budget data ends 2017.



e the dashed line: health is a bigger slice of the platform than of the budget.

With Medicare in the budget (first plot), platform attention falls below budget share after the late 1960s, when Medicare launched. With Medicare out (second plot), the ratio hovers around 1. The divergence is largely a Medicare story. Sentences naming Medicare are only about 7% of Health sentences, so removing them barely changes the platform side.

Does removing Medicare sentences change the picture?

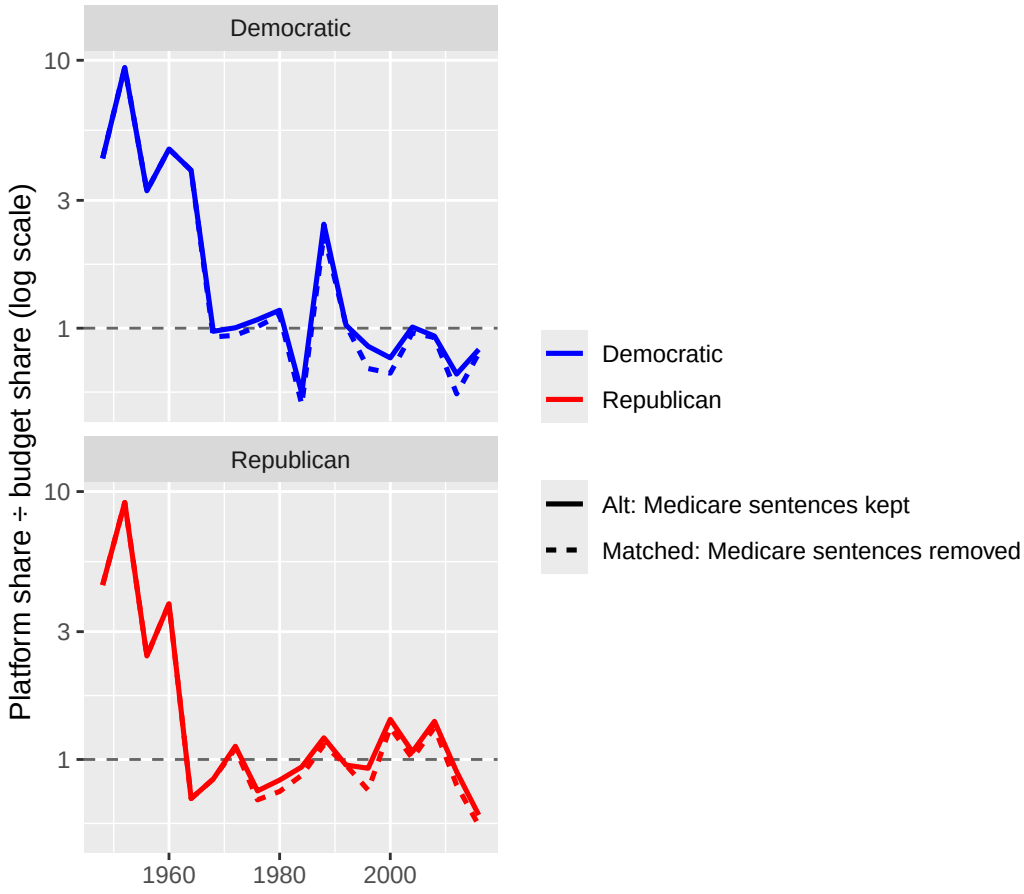
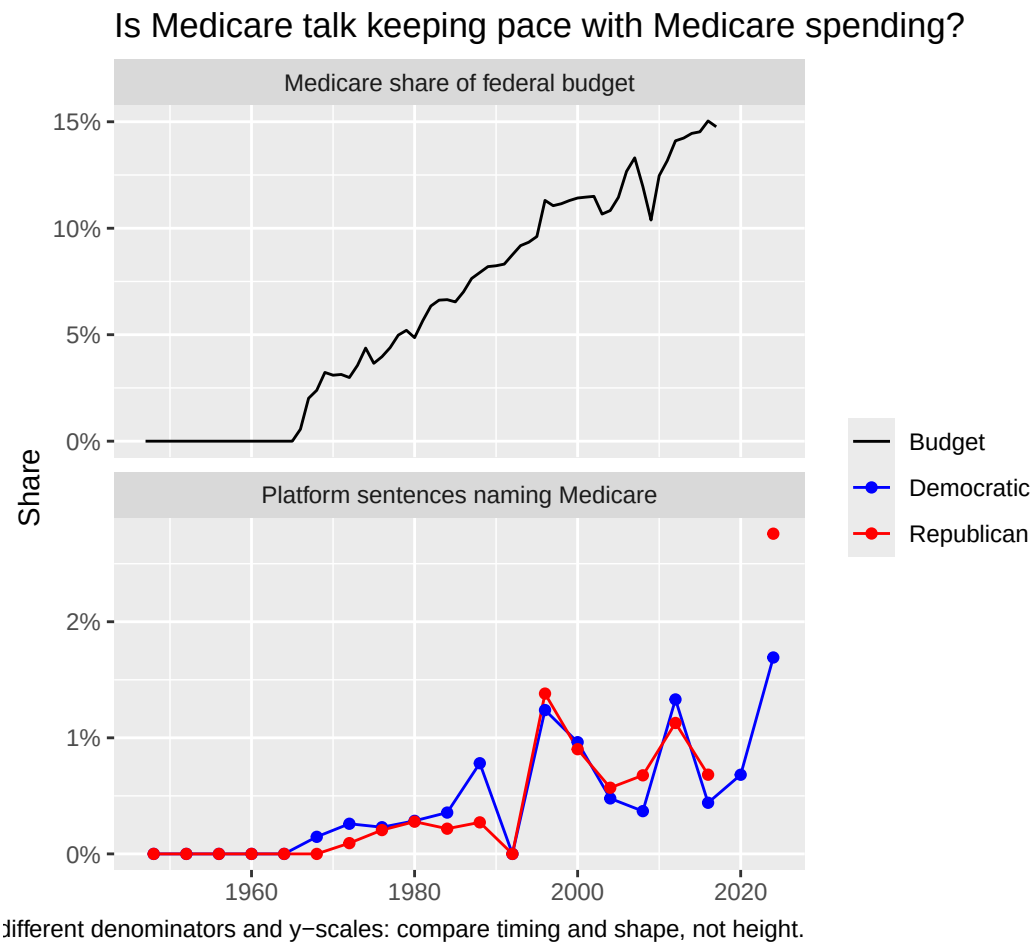
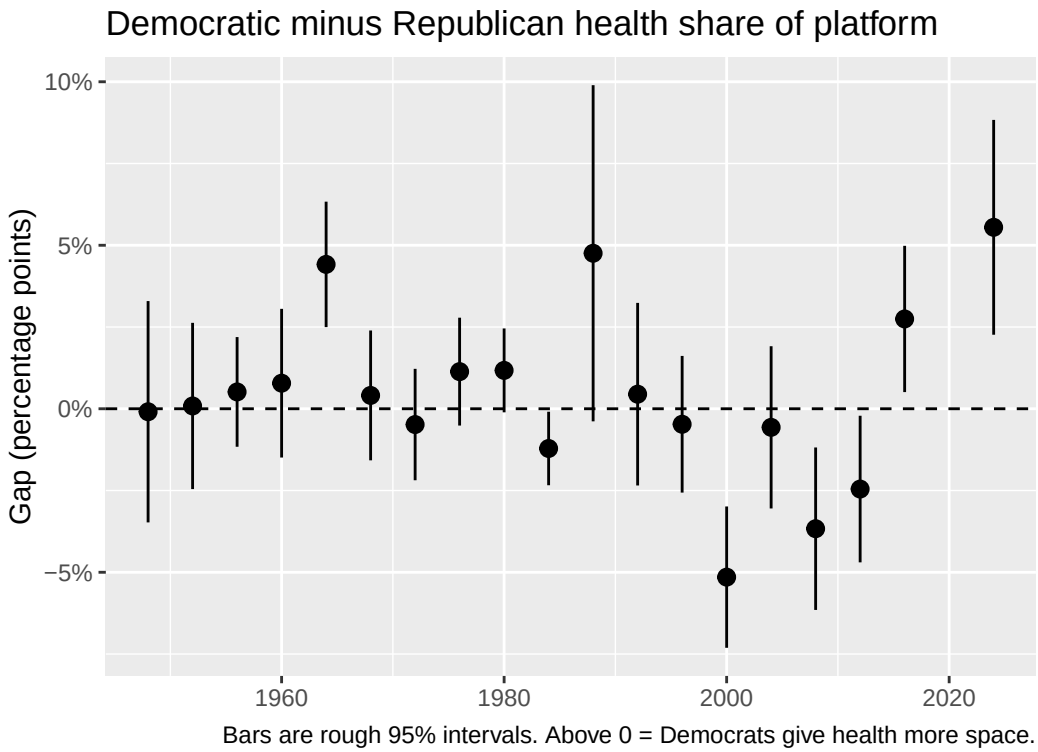


Figure 4: Medicare talk vs. Medicare spending



Medicare's budget share rises steadily from 1966. Platform mentions of Medicare stay small, mostly under 1.5% until 2024, and rise later. Both parties peak together in 1996, but the text shows them arguing opposite positions: equal attention, opposite stances. 1992 has zero mentions despite normal Health volume; the sentences I read framed health as system-wide reform.

Figure 5: Party gap



party	year	total	health	share
Democratic	1964	813	44	0.054
Republican	1964	301	3	0.010
Democratic	1984	1685	32	0.019
Republican	1984	1381	43	0.031
Democratic	2000	1039	65	0.063
Republican	2000	1552	177	0.114
Democratic	2008	1086	82	0.076
Republican	2008	1034	116	0.112
Democratic	2012	1052	77	0.073
Republican	2012	1330	130	0.098
Democratic	2016	1135	122	0.107
Republican	2016	1612	129	0.080
Democratic	2024	1832	228	0.124
Republican	2024	290	20	0.069

On average the parties give health about equal space (mean gap 0.4 points; Democrats higher

in 11 of 19 years), but seven years have intervals excluding zero. The counts show different sources: 2000 and 2008 are real emphasis gaps (Republicans wrote more Health sentences), while 2016 is mostly a length gap (similar Health counts, longer Republican platform).

Caveats

- Shares depend on platform length, and shares from different sources have different denominators.
- Intervals in Figure 5 treat sentences as independent, so they are too narrow. Small counts (Republican 1964 and 2024, Democratic 1988) are unreliable.
- Medicare search is a text-match floor; it misses indirect references.
- Budget data ends in 2017. Budget authority is net of offsetting receipts.
- The Medicare budget definition (550 vs. 550+571) changes Figure 3 a lot.

Jones, Baumgartner, Theriault, Epp, Khandekar & Little. 2025. *Policy Agendas Project: Codebook.*